

Facebook-Cambridge Analytica Case

Fletcher Robson

Ferris State University

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Dr. Amy Ruba

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In today's world, data is money and can be utilized to gain a multitude of insights on human behavior. Analyzing individual's social media data can lead to targeted advertising and algorithm changes that lead to one's emotions changing. Companies such as Meta, X, and Google have access to millions of users' data. It is their job to protect the users' data and privacy, especially from unconsensual use of data. Meta, the parent company of applications such as Facebook, Instagram, and WhatsApp, experienced a major scandal regarding leaking/nonconsensual use of user data. This event happened on Facebook in collaboration with Cambridge Analytica, a company who specializes in harvesting user data and targeted advertising. This paper will overview the Facebook-Cambridge Analytica case, discuss ethical issues of using big data, and responses/consequences of the case.

Facebook a social media platform, with billions of monthly users was exposed in 2018 for a scandal regarding the nonconsensual use of millions of users' data. Cambridge Analytica, a political data firm specializing in targeted advertising, was the primary perpetrator of this scandal. They were able to access this information through a Facebook platform called Open Graph (Meredith, 2018). Open Graph allowed external developers to contact Facebook users and ask for access to personal data (Meredith, 2018). When permission was granted, developers could also access the users' friend's data (Meredith, 2018). This is where Cambridge Analytica becomes involved through an app they developed named "thisisyourdigitallife" (Meredith, 2018). This app paid users to answer questions regarding their psychological profile (Meredith, 2018). The app then took personal data from the survey participants (Meredith, 2018). User data along with their Facebook friend's information was harvested prior to Facebook's change in developer access to data in 2014 (Meredith, 2018). By this point, Cambridge Analytica had already collected the data they needed. It was not until 2018 when The Guardian and New York

Times exposed the fact Cambridge Analytica had harvested 87 million Facebook users' data (Meredith, 2018). It was found that this information was being used to create psychological profiles and deliver targeted political advertisements (Harbath, 2023). The targeted political ads were used to aid Ted Cruz and Donald Trump in their 2016 campaigns (Meredith, 2018). After the breach was made public, Facebook revoked access for Cambridge Analytica along with releasing new measures to secure user data (Harbath, 2023). Facebook's CEO Mark Zuckerberg later had to testify in front of the Senate Judiciary and Commerce Committee regarding what happened in the case (Meredith, 2018).

With the background of the case established, it is important to discuss the ethical issues surrounding the use of big data. Issues such as informed consent, data privacy and ownership, exploitation and manipulation, and lack of transparency/accountability will be addressed. Informed consent is the principle that individuals must be explicitly notified that their data will be collected and used before doing so. The ethical issue of informed consent is pertinent in today's digital society. Personal information is important to individuals as it is what differentiates them from others. When a company collects user data and does not tell users, it is like stealing one's personal items. In the Cambridge Analytica case, participants in the surveys did not know their information would be collected and used (Meredith, 2018). This is a clear breach of privacy and neglect of informed consent. Although this was made possible through a loophole, this is still unethical. Data privacy and ownership are another ethical issue that were manipulated in the Cambridge Analytica case. Data privacy refers to an individual's right to control how their personal information is collected, stored, and used. This means companies cannot take information that users do not want to share. Along with this, if they have given consent to take data, they must also be okay with how long it is being stored and what it is being

used for. In the case of Facebook and Cambridge Analytica, users' data was not being kept private, and Facebook essentially owned their information. At the end of the data platforms such as Facebook have the ethical necessity to treat user data as private property as they do not own it. Exploitation and manipulation of data is another concern with the use of big data. Exploitation of data is when data is used in a way individuals are not okay with. Along with this, the exploitation of data can lead to users being manipulated with insights on the data that was taken. Facebook and Cambridge Analytica exploited user information to manipulate users by creating targeted advertisements. Users were manipulated by their own personal information to influence their views on politics. Exploiting and manipulating users with their own information is in no way ever ethical. The last ethical issue that will be addressed is the lack of transparency and accountability when using big data. Companies such as Facebook have the ethical responsibility to be transparent and accountable for the actions they are taking. They must let users know what they are doing with information, and if rights are violated, they must be held accountable. It took media companies to expose the breach for Facebook to be transparent to their users (Meredith, 2018). Facebook was then held accountable by the Senate to pay 725 million dollars in damages (Bleichmar Fonti & Auld LLP, 2023). Issues such as informed consent, data privacy and ownership, exploitation and manipulation, and lack of transparency all need to be addressed when collecting, storing, and using big data.

Ethical issues regarding the Facebook-Cambridge Analytica case have been addressed; responses and consequences of the case now must be addressed. Some aforementioned consequences of the case are the biggest fine on a tech company being given to Facebook by the FTC totaling 725 million dollars (Bleichmar Fonti & Auld LLP, 2023). In response to millions of user data being used for targeted political advertising, Cambridge Analytica filed for bankruptcy in 2018 (FTC,

2019). The outing of this case raised public awareness of data privacy across the world. This case exposed how personal information can be collected and used by companies on the internet. Major restrictions were also put on Facebook individually after the case. These restrictions require overlapping channels of compliance regarding their privacy and transparency decision making (Federal Trade Commission, 2019). An independent privacy committee was also implemented into Facebook's board of directors (Federal Trade Commission, 2019). Along with this Facebook had to create compliance officer positions who must contact the FTC quarterly (Federal Trade Commission, 2019). Not only were requirements put onto Facebook, but legislation was also made for all tech companies. Legislative acts such as the Digital Services and Digital Markets act were implemented in the EU (Harbath, 2023). Companies such as Twitter banned political ads and google reduced targeted advertisements (Harbath, 2023). This case has made me reflect on how important personal data and information is. Having a background in AI, I recognize how important and useful data can be. The fact that personal data can be used to manipulate oneself is frightening. This makes me think of social media algorithms driving what people see. This can then lead to the radicalization of individuals as they are only given information that keeps them on applications. Data can be used to gain significant insights on one's mental state and behaviors. I believe the largest issues regarding big data are informed consent and exploitation. If one does not know their data is being used and then they are manipulated, this is obscenely unethical. As the advancement of AI continues, adaptable restrictions and regulations will ultimately need to be implemented.

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